Mohammad Fahim Dashty, who was writing a book on Massoud, were injured.[80] With its key binding force gone, Massoud's absence crippled the United Front and led to its eventual disintegration. For the partisans, India had lost its main partner on the ground in Afghanistan, raising questions of how to handle this leadership vacuum (Rabbani had developed serious differences with many by then). But the dilemma was short-lived. Subsequent attacks on the World Trade Center in New York on 11 September 2001 changed everything. The US decision to use military force to capture bin Laden and oust the Taliban was a blessing for the partisans who found allies in the world's sole superpower soon after losing Massoud.

Don't trust the Americans

The US response in the wake of the 9/11 attacks was a short-lived blessing for the partisans. The American bombing campaign in Afghanistan was accompanied by heightened tension between India and Pakistan. On 1 October 2001, four powerful bombs went off in the Jammu and Kashmir (J&K) state legislative assembly complex killing thirty-eight people.[81] J&K chief minister Farooq Abdullah was a target, and the Jaish-e-Mohammad, a jihadi group active in Kashmir and supported by Pakistan, took responsibility for the attack. In response, Vajpayee wrote an urgent letter to President Bush offering support in Afghanistan and imploring him to pressurise Musharraf to control the JeM. He had already undertaken a three-nation tour of Russia, the US and the UK after the 9/11 attacks to articulate India's stance on terrorism.[82] Though hot-pursuit of militants in Pakistan-administered Kashmir was not launched, the security apparatus in Kashmir had been tightened and put on high alert.[83] 'Pakistan must understand', wrote Vajpayee (to Bush), 'that there is a limit to the patience of the people of India.'[84] Jaswant Singh publicly offered military help to the US and argued that 'if one of the instruments of terrorism is military, and the whole point of spreading terror is through military means, how can you respond to a strike of steel by any other means than steel?'[85] Further demonstrating India's angst about cross-border terrorism, Vajpayee made a vigorous anti-terrorism pitch at the UNGA on 10 November 2001, endorsed the UNSC Resolution 1373, and